

has changed, and we forget that changing direction doesn't happen instantly. We need to slow down first, and that requires friction.

When you move from spending on a whim to conscious consumption, there's a lot of friction. Not only have we and the people around us been told to desire in ever-increasing quantities, we also use shopping as an escape from and solution to many of our problems.

On your no-spend challenge, and when spending in general, the biggest obstacle you'll come up against is impulse spending, which is simply unplanned spending. It's deciding to buy something, then immediately buying it. A practice that is glamorized in media. I remember growing up watching actors on TV shows and movies making spontaneous purchases, saying things like "This round's on me boys!" to the whole bar and "Oh, what the heck, I'll take one of each!" to the boutique salesclerk. That's what I thought being an adult looked like, being able to spontaneously buy whatever you want.

When you Google "how to stop impulse spending," you'll get answers like "make a budget and stick to it," "reflect before buying," and "stick to a shopping list." These answers are simultaneously infuriating and hilarious, because if I could stick to a shopping list, I wouldn't be googling "how to stop impulse spending!" After a lifetime of being told to buy what you want when you want it, no one is showing their work on how to reverse that desire. And we kinda get it—it can be a complex topic. Impulse control and decision-making are run by several different parts of your brain. But in order to get to the root of why we impulse spend, we need to be looking at where impulse control comes from.

The part of our brain responsible for decision-making and impulse control is the prefrontal cortex. The prefrontal cortex operates slowly and is logical and precise. Unfortunately, our brains like to work quickly. It's a good thing overall, like in the instances of real danger where your survival brain kicks into that fight, flight, or freeze mode. It's great when a bear is about to attack you, but it's less helpful when you're trying to cut down on impulsive decisions. The limbic system is responsible for our survival brain, and it operates fast. Because of its correlation with keeping you alive, when dopamine is released, your brain prioritizes your survival brain. That's why a no-spend challenge is a great first step in stabilizing your dopamine receptor pathways. Because you can't truly "fast" from dopamine, and you don't want to—it's a vital neurotransmitter. While it rises in response to